



SKIF-USA

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SKIF-USA

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Message from the Board

Dear Members,

2025 was a year full of SKIF-USA events. Our members hosted four national tours with Kancho Kanazawa (in both Hawaii and on the mainland), Shuseki Shihan Murakami, and Sensei Hiroyi Kanazawa. The Board was also honored to have three GHQ Zoom training sessions. We are grateful to all the sponsors, participants, and supporters.

It was also a year when the Board developed additional organizational systems to assist our members with day-to-day operations. This included expanded online payment options, online event registration, online elections, and improved organizational document archiving.

2026 will also feature international and national training in Japan, Oregon, Texas, Ohio, California, and Hawaii. We will also offer Zoom sessions with GHQ instructors. Please check our website for further information. There will also be the 15th SKIF World Championship in Turkey, November 9-15. Please let Sensei Ruben know if you are interested in securing a position on the team.

Organizational projects SKIF-USA would like to focus on this year include promoting our high-ranking instructors to teach across the country at our member dojos. We have several 6th Dan and above instructors who are highly knowledgeable in the SKIF system. If you are interested in hosting a USA instructor for a seminar, please let us know.

We are also planning to hold another Zoom Chief Instructors meeting, where instructors can discuss ideas and concerns with the Board.

We would like to remind everyone that SKIF-USA is only as strong as our membership. Only with your participation can we grow. This is your organization, and the Board comprises and is elected by our members. If you have an idea, please share it with a member of our Board. We also ask that you participate in supporting our events, the newsletter, and the Board. Every Fall, several Board seats are filled by election. Please consider running and, of course, please vote.

We also ask that you stay current on all membership and dojo renewals. Only with timely payment of dues can we submit our renewals to GHQ. As a friendly reminder, our two primary ways to raise funds for tours and seminars are through your participation in our Zoom seminars and our ISM program. The ISM (Individual Student Membership) program is where individual students in a dojo can join SKIF-USA through their dojo's membership in SKIF-USA. To test for Dan Rank, an examinee must have this membership; otherwise, they will not be allowed to test. But an ISM membership is recommended for 7th Kyu and up. This allows the individual student to feel part of a larger family and helps them understand the global significance of Shotokan Karate and SKIF. Please encourage all your students to join.

Finally, we encourage all our members to participate in the SKIF training on Patreon. This is direct training with GHQ instructors. Instructors in particular need to study this training to ensure the most current interpretation of Soke's curriculum.

The Board wishes all our members a prosperous and peaceful New Year.

Oss!
Chris Johnson
General Secretary
SKIF-USA

Taikyoku Shodan - An Instructor's Perspective

by Juan Rafael Guzman Diaz

Introduction to Taikyoku Shodan

Taikyoku Shodan (太極初段) stands as the foundational kata within the curriculum, serving as the first and most critical building block for a student's development. Its name, translating to "great ultimate first level," signifies its strategic importance in establishing the core principles of movement, balance, and technique. The kata is intentionally minimalist in its construction, designed to instill a deep and intuitive understanding of the fundamentals before introducing more complex sequences. The entire form is performed using only one primary stance, the forward-bent stance (Zenkutsu Dachi), and two core techniques: the low-level sweep (Gedan Barai) and the middle-level lunge punch (Chudan Oi Zuki). This deliberate simplicity allows students and instructors to focus exclusively on the quality of these foundational elements. To properly teach and understand this form, a precise command of the terminology is essential.

Terminology

The use of precise Japanese terminology is critical not only for accurate instruction but also for the preservation of martial arts tradition. Clear, consistent language ensures that the core concepts of stance, technique, and spirit are transmitted without ambiguity.

Analysis of Core Components

The pedagogical value of Taikyoku Shodan lies in its focused repetition of a few essential elements. By deconstructing the kata into its core components—stances, techniques, and concepts—an instructor can ensure that each piece is mastered individually.

Proficiency in these individual elements is a non-negotiable prerequisite for performing the complete sequence with the required precision and spirit.

Foundational Stances (Dachi)

- *Musubi-Dachi* (結び立ち, the "joined/tying stance"): This stance is used exclusively for the formal opening and closing of the kata, during the initial and final bow (Rei).
- *Soto-Hachiji-Dachi* (外八字立ち, the "outside number-eight-character [八] stance"): This is the ready stance assumed for *Yoi-no-Kamae* immediately after the opening bow and just before the final bow.
- *Zenkutsu-Dachi* (前屈立ち, the "forward-bent stance"): This is the single, exclusive stance used during the performance of the kata's entire main sequence, for both blocking and punching techniques.

Core Techniques (Waza)

- *Gedan-Barai* (下段払い, the "low-level sweep"): The low-level sweep is the defensive technique of the kata. It is executed after every turn, establishing the correct position and guard before advancing.
- *Chudan Oi-Zuki* (中段追い突き, the "middle-level lunge thrust"): The middle-level lunge thrust is the sole offensive technique. It is used for every forward-stepping strike throughout the form.

Essential Concepts

- *Yoi-no-Kamae* (良 い の 構 え): This is the formal ready posture, characterized by the arms and fists being held at the front of the body while in *Soto-Hachiji-Dachi*.

- *Kiai* (気 合): The spirited shout is executed at two specific points in the kata to demonstrate focus and power: on the third punch of the first forward sequence and on the third punch of the second forward sequence (while facing the back).

- *Hara* (腹): The center of the body is the source of vocal power used to properly announce the name of the kata, "Taikyoku Shodan," before the performance begins.

With these core components now clearly defined, we will proceed to the complete, step-by-step sequence of the form.

The Complete Kata Sequence

This section provides the definitive, step-by-step guide for instructors teaching Taikyoku Shodan. The following sequence must be taught with meticulous attention to direction, footwork, and technique to ensure student proficiency and adherence to the form's rigid structure. Each movement must be precise and deliberate.

1. *Rei* (Bow): Begin in *Musubi-Dachi* with hands at the side and fingers together. Execute a bow.

2. *Kamae* (Ready): Announce the kata name, "Taikyoku Shodan," using the *Hara*. Open the right leg to the right to assume *Soto-Hachiji-Dachi*. Assume *Yoi-no-Kamae* with fists at the front of the body, facing front.

3. Move 1: Turn 90 degrees to the left, establishing a left *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Gedan-Barai*.

4. Move 2: Step forward in the left direction into a right *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki*.

5. Move 3: Using the back (left) foot as a pivot point, turn 180 degrees clockwise with the front (right) foot. End facing the right direction in a right *Zenkutsu-Dachi* and execute *Gedan-Barai*.

6. Move 4: Step forward in the right direction into a left *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki*.

7. Move 5: Using the back (right) foot as a pivot point, turn 90 degrees counterclockwise with the front (left) foot. End facing the front direction in a left *Zenkutsu-Dachi* and execute *Gedan-Barai*.

8. Move 6: Step forward with the right foot into a right *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki*.

9. Move 7: Step forward with the left foot into a left *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki*.

10. Move 8: Step forward with the right foot into a right *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki* with the first *Kiai*.

11. Move 9: Using the front (right) foot as a pivot point, turn 270 degrees counterclockwise with the back (left) foot. End facing the right direction in a left *Zenkutsu-Dachi* and execute *Gedan-Barai*.

12. Move 10: Step forward in the right direction into a right *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki*.

13. Move 11: Using the back (left) foot as a pivot point, turn 180 degrees clockwise with the front (right) foot. End facing the left direction in a right *Zenkutsu-Dachi* and execute *Gedan-Barai*.

14. Move 12: Step forward in the left direction into a left *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki*.

15. Move 13: Using the back (right) foot as a pivot point, turn 90 degrees counterclockwise with the front (left) foot. End facing the back direction in a left *Zenkutsu-Dachi* and execute *Gedan-Barai*.

16. Move 14: Step forward with the right foot into a right *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki*.

17. Move 15: Step forward with the left foot into a left *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki*.

18. Move 16: Step forward with the right foot into a right *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki* with the second and final *Kiai*.

19. Move 17: Using the front (right) foot as a pivot point, turn 270 degrees counterclockwise with the back (left) foot. End facing the left direction in a left *Zenkutsu-Dachi* and execute *Gedan-Barai*.

20. Move 18: Step forward in the left direction into a right *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki*.

21. Move 19: Using the back (left) foot as a pivot point, turn 180 degrees clockwise with the front (right) foot. End facing the right direction in a right *Zenkutsu-Dachi* and execute *Gedan-Barai*.

22. Move 20: Step forward in the right direction into a left *Zenkutsu-Dachi*. Execute *Chudan Oi-Zuki*.

23. Return to Yoi: Step the front (left) leg back, turning to face the front direction. Return to *Soto-Hachiji-Dachi* and the *Yoi-no-Kamae* posture.

24. Return to *Musubi-Dachi*: Move the right leg in next to the left leg to assume *Musubi-Dachi*.

25. Final Rei (Bow): With hands at the side and fingers together, execute the final bow. With the final bow complete, the physical execution of the kata is finished, allowing us to reflect on its fundamental purpose for the developing student.

Concluding Summary for Instructors

Taikyoku Shodan is not a kata of complexity but of purity. Its purpose is to build a student's entire foundation upon a small, perfectible set of skills. The form is a physical exercise in discipline, constructed exclusively from the repetition of one primary stance (*Zenkutsu Dachi*) and two fundamental techniques (*Gedan Barai* and *Chudan Oi Zuki*). As an instructor, your primary goal is to ensure that every repetition of these basics is performed with maximal focus and precision. This disciplined repetition is not merely for memorization; it is for forging correct muscle memory and neuromuscular pathways that will prevent the formation of bad habits in more advanced training. Mastery of Taikyoku Shodan is the mastery of the very basics upon which all future learning will depend, making it the true cornerstone of a student's karate journey.

Walking the Ways

by Atilla Zoard Toth

The year 2025 has become so far, the busiest year for me on my ongoing karate journey with SKIF-USA. It was my pleasure to have the opportunity to attend three different *gasshuku* and to make my relationship with the organization stronger. No matter where I go to participate in any karate training or camp, there is always something special in the atmosphere that is hard to describe but easier to emerge in, an overwhelming sense of belonging not only to a group of people but to a community filled with enthusiastic energy and comradeship.

To give a very special point of view of my earlier experiences with some of the well-respected teachers from other popular organizations, not every *gasshuku* made sense entirely as much as I remember. Occasionally, a whole hour went by doing a thousand *gyaku-zuki* and five hundred *maegeri*. Of course, after the class, we felt challenged and tired, but most likely filled with unanswered questions on what we learned on that day.

Anytime, Murakami Sensei visits Houston, Texas, I understand karate and Budō deeper and do not leave with question marks in my head. His teaching makes sense in terms of embracing the fighting spirit of a warrior (*tōshi*), explaining body mechanics, and more relevantly, giving a brand-new aspect on adapting karate to the aging body. As I experience minor injuries more often in my regular practice, listening to the body and relearning a few of the moves to better aid my goals have become more important.

My next stop brought me to New York to experience a spectacular sight on its own, a beautiful facility high up in the sky. I will not lie if I tell you that I caught myself a few times staring through the windows during training, but of course, my main focus still remained on Kancho Kanazawa Sensei's teaching. His athleticism and smooth movements are unmatched; every technique was presented by textbooks like precision and great forms. Within the two classes he taught, I learned more about the proper execution of kihon, and kumite moves and the flow of energy coming from the ground through the body. Gratefully, there was a smoothie shop right at the corner of the facility that helped me to recoup my energy and finish my journey in the Big Apple.

Finally, the last stop came as a surprise, Cincinnati, not because that was my first time seeing the beautifully crafted Doshinkai Dojo, but because that was my first time seeing Hiyori Kanazawa Sensei in person. As she can be seen in many of the Kuro-Obi YouTube series, her humble and kind personality did not disappoint me. I was very excited about learning Gojushiho Dai and, especially, Gankaku Sho, two of the katas that can be complex and beautiful at the same time. Her energy and enthusiasm helped me to keep going and do my very best even though I felt exhausted at one point, but who didn't? She inspired me to go back to the base line and merge myself more into learning the *kihon-ippon-kumite* and *jiyu-ippon-kumite* series.

I don't think I can ever remember such a large number of participations for a dinner organized to karatekas that occurred on Saturday, many of my peers even had to occupy another long sitting area because the six-seven tables pushed together were not enough to accommodate everyone. I sat down next to a gentleman that I did not know before and started discussing various matters of topics from karate to life. It went on until the moment of realization hitting me hard by recognizing his accent, it was my accent as well. Both of us broke out in laughter after figuring out that we're Hungarians and even named the same, the two Attilas.



Kancho Kanazawa in Hawaii

by SKIF Hawaii

Shotokan Karate-Do International Federation (SKIF) Hawaii had the honor of hosting Kancho Nobuaki Kanazawa from March 6 to 9, 2025. This visit included dojo training sessions, weekend seminars, and Dan examinations, offering a unique and valuable experience for those in attendance.

Leading up to the weekend seminars, Kancho conducted dojo training sessions with the Iwilei dojo, as well as a combined session with the Windward dojo and the Pearl City dojo. He presented an innovative approach to *Okuri-Jiyu-Ippon-Kumite* (follow-through, free-style, one-step kumite), where two *Jiyu-Ippon-Kumite* combinations were continuously connected.

The main seminar on Saturday brought together SKIF dojos from across the outer islands, including Kona-Hawaii and Waikoloa on the Big Island. The event also included attendees from independent Shotokan dojos and other disciplines, such as members of Funakoshi Shotokan Karate and United Goju-Kan Karate Do Hawaii.



Among the highlights was the participation of Nobuaki Satsukawa, Chief Instructor of the Tokyo City University (TCU) Karate Club, accompanied by six of his students. They performed an impressive kumite demonstration and team kata performance of Enpi.

During the Dan examinations, Hawaii Sensei Victor Takemori, Kudan, a long-time friend and student of the late Soke Hirokazu Kanazawa, attended and sat alongside Kancho.

On Sunday, Kancho led a technical seminar focused on refining black belt instruction, emphasizing consistency and precision in teaching. The session, attended by various black belts from all Hawaii Dojos, offered valuable direction on maintaining high standards of instruction.

SKIF Hawaii is sincerely grateful to Kancho Kanazawa for his dedication and approach. With humility, kindness, and patience, he connects with each Karateka, meeting them at their individual skill and ability levels. We look forward to future visits and the opportunity to continue learning and developing under his guidance.



A Karate Road Trip

by Richard Dionne

Early June 17th, I loaded the car for San Jose California looking forward to Kancho's annual trip to the United States. Pulling in 10 hours later with a few hours to spare before training I laid down to relax in preparation for some good training.

The first night of training with Kanazawa Kancho was for SKIF members only inside the Yu-Ai Kai Center in San Jose. Training was in a banquet room on the second floor. Jay Castellano Hanshi and the executive board of Satsuma Dojo graciously welcomed me upon my arrival. Kancho touched on the three *kihon*, *Jiyu-Ippon-Kumite* and *kata* with Heian Yondan, Kanku Dai and Meikyo for kata.



The next day I had time to walk around San Jose and its Japantown. I never had the opportunity to visit San Jose. San Jose Japantown though started by Japanese immigrants, but became a magnet for many Asian Pacific immigrants. Only a few blocks square it holds onto its Asian roots with restraints, gift shops, and street art.

The second night of training was open to all interested karate-ka at the Cambell Community Center in Campbell CA.

Kancho drilled the attendees through additional *kihon* and *Jiyu-Ippon*. Both nights he discussed how to generate power through wave action radiating through the spin and not just the hip rotation. I learn something new every time I train with Kanazawa Kancho that requires me to take a deep exploration.

I also bumped into old comrades from my Ryobu Kai days. I have found only 3 degrees of separation in the karate community. Whether with people I know or people with shared acquaintances, a lifelong bond is created through mutual training experiences.

With the seminar concluded, the next leg of my journey began. After scheduling Kancho's seminar, I realized my old dojo in California was conducting its annual tournament a couple of days afterwards. Seemed like a good idea to go see old friends and participate in a well-run shobu ippon tournament. The Pacific Coast Championship started in 1991. This was their first tournament after covid.

Friday night before the tournament Victor Young (founder of Camarillo Shotokan) and Michael Young (Goju-ryu, Anchorage AK) conducted a joint seminar on kumite. Good drills and practical tatami advice for kumite. Always good training when my dogi pants are wet afterwards.

The tournament was well organized. Check-in was quick and uneventful. Food and equipment vendors available. I refereed Kobudo and youth divisions until noon when I needed to prepare for the divisions I was competing in. After the tournament we retreated to a local brewery to relax after a long day. The highlight of the event was catching up with old friends and making new ones.

What this trip meant to me was that as karate-ka we are like family. We train, we sweat, we bond through shared experience and goals. Life may take us in different directions. Coming together at seminars or tournaments is like a family reunion. It's like that second cousin you haven't seen in 15 years. You see them, the room lightens, and you spend the next hour catching up. I was greeted warmly everywhere I went, and look forward to train with Kanazawa Kancho at the Satsuma Dojo next year.



The Most Important Thing in Karate

by Jeff Christian

Karate-Do is about keeping focus on the present, what is right before us. That truth was obvious when Sensei Murakami held our weekend seminar in Houston, Texas in February. The first two-hour session was a lesson from the past to keep us grounded in the present.

Sensei Murakami taught us what Sensei Kanazawa taught him, even calling it “the most important thing in Karate.” This lesson was a collection of “first things” that Sensei Kanazawa received from his teachers through the years.

1. Strong Stance: Every block, punch, and kick begins with a strong stance. With a solid, rooted stance, every technique is possible; without a good stance, there is no karate. When I teach our beginners, I often say, “Bend your knee.” But we also try to emphasize what bending your knee accomplishes, so we say, “Root your stance.” Zenkutsu means, “forward bend” or “front bend.” Sensei Murakami explained that this is not just about bending the front knee, but especially bending the front hip. This is what makes a strong stance. And a strong stance is “the most important thing in Karate.”

2. Body Position: From our hips, we can bend forward and back, side to side, and we can also twist left and right. At any point, one or more of these may be off kilter.



For example, perhaps we lean forward too much in order to advance a punch, thus throwing off our center of gravity. Such a stance is unstable and without foundation. Again, “Root your stance.” Pay attention to your centerline at all times. Maintain good posture. Always be aware of good body position.

3. Hips and Hara: Following point number two, movement in any stance, block, punch, or kick originates from the hips and hara, your core. If the hips and hara are not involved, stance and body position will be weak. The hara needs to remain strong and engaged throughout our movements, driving the hips at all times. If strong stance is “the most important thing in karate,” your hips and hara contribute to your strong stance.

4. Relax Shoulders: This one is simple to hear, simple to explain, but difficult to remember. When we tense our shoulders, we lose speed and power. Our blocks contract upward, or closer to our bodies. But this one needs little explanation. It takes focus and practice. Relax your shoulders.

Sensei Murakami explained that these lessons come together in Kanku Dai. He said that Kanku Dai is the hardest and most important kata, even going so far as to say, “If you do Kanku Dai, you know all of Shotokan Karate.” Whether by yourself, or training with your dojo, Kanku Dai is an opportunity to practice the four things listed above that together make up “the most important thing in karate.”

Morote-Uke - Evolution and Tradition

by Ricardo Neves

Morote-Uke (諸手受け) is a block that uses both hands: a blocking hand and a supporting hand. It appears for the first time to a Karate student in the kata Heian Nidan, hence establishing itself as a rather fundamental technique in the Shotokan curriculum.

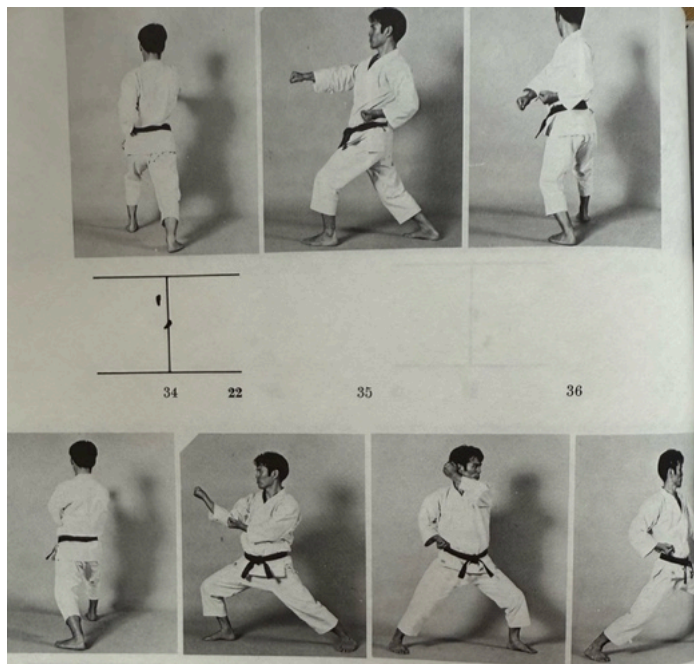
Just as many other Karate techniques, its execution evolved and incorporated the interpretation of the instructors and their schools. Although the “final” form is virtually identical in all school, the process to get get seems to have varied - or not - quite a lot. Do both arms swing during preparation or just one? Do they remain parallel or one goes over the other? If they go does the hand go over the elbow, or inside of it? What is the “SKIF way” of doing it?

This is by no means a complete or final discussion on the topic, nor is to assert which one is more “correct” than the other. It is my intention in this short article to solely take you in a journey though several documented examples of how this technique has been executed by different people over time. Of course this comparison is limited to what static photos can capture.

Part I - The early days

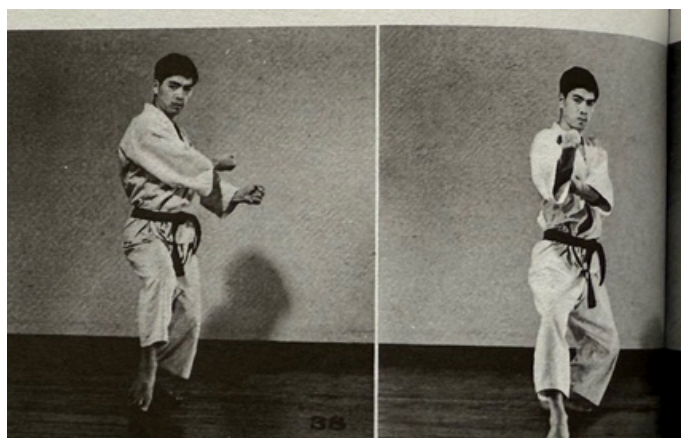
“Karate-Do Kyohan: The Master Text”, Funakoshi G., 1956

The earliest record I found was in Funakoshi’s sensei Oshima’s translation of the original text to english. Here we can note only one arm swinging during preparation, while the other hand remains in *hikite* position.



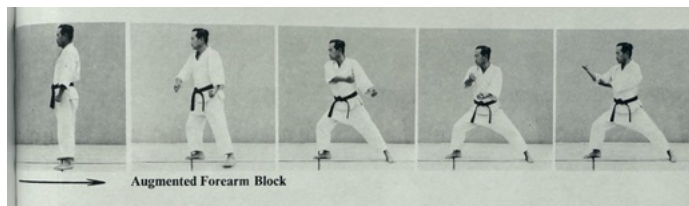
“Karate: the art of ‘empty hand’ fighting”, Nishiyama H., 1960

In the seminal publication of sensei Nishiyama, one can see a Soke Kanazawa in his late 20s executing the technique swinging both arms, with the blocking hand going over the supporting hand during preparation. Also note the preparation arm remains at around 45 degrees.



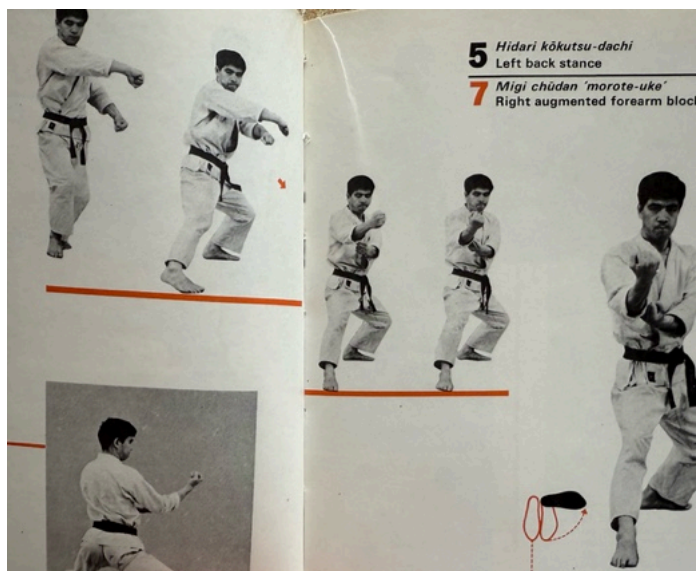
"Dynamic Karate", Nakayama M., 1966

In the first major Shotokan publication to by then leader of the JKA, demonstrates the morote-uke step-by-step. In there we can observe a wider opening of the arms during preparation (roughly 90s degree or more). both arms are extended with the blocking hand on the inside of the elbow of the supporting hand.



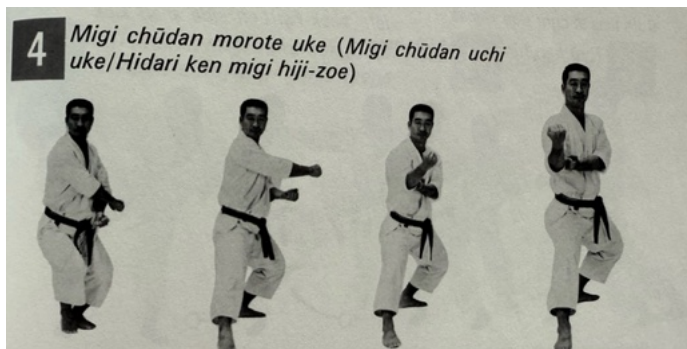
"Karate Kata Heian 5", Nakayama M., 1969

Just a few years later, sensei Nakayama launches a series of books covering Kata. In the fifth volume, which covers the Heian Godan, Soke Kanazawa demonstrating this technique. Note the similarity to his execution in Nishiyama's book, preparing the block with the blocking hand going above the supporting hand elbow (although in this picture we still see both arms separated, following Nakayama's method), and narrower opening of the supporting hand, remaining nearly at 45 degrees to the side.



"Best Karate - Vol.5", Nakayama M., 1979

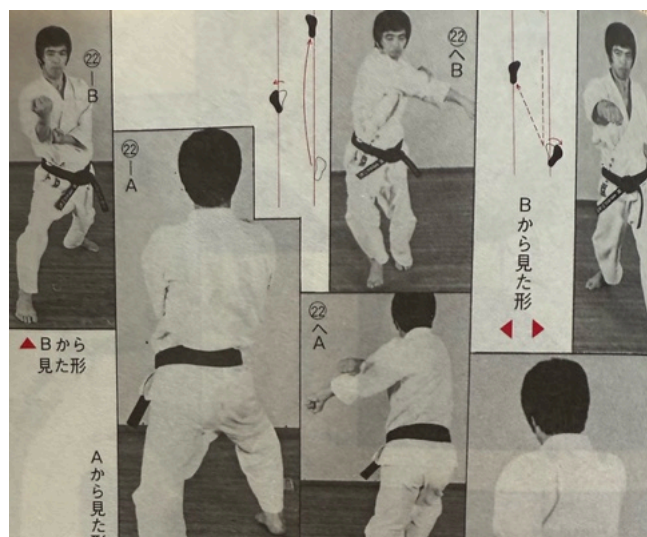
In the fifth Volume of the seminal work by sensei Nakayama, which covers the Heian and Tekki kata, Osaka sensei shows preparation with only one arms, while the hikite hand remains palm-up. Yet a different way, and also a testimony how each instructor had their personal way of executing the technique.



Part II - SKIF Tradition

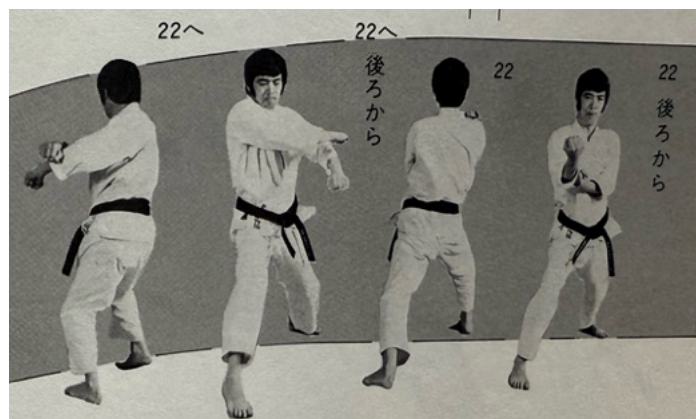
"新空手道 [New Karate-do]", Kanazawa, H. 1977 (Japanese edition)

In what it seems to be the first official SKI publication, Kanazawa shows his method of preparing the block, with the blocking hand above the supporting arm. This would remain a constant in his technique and SKIF syllabus, and attests to the consistency of his technique since the early days.



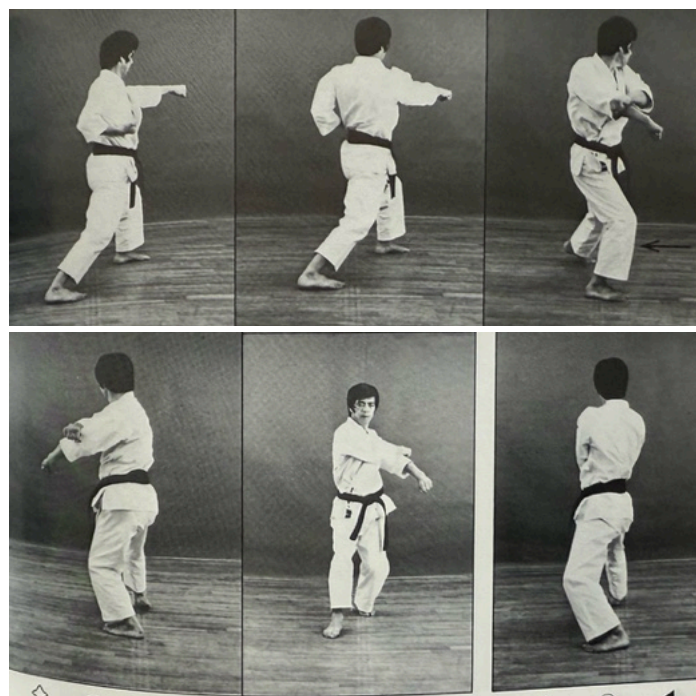
“空手 [Karate]”, Kanazawa H., 1978 (Japanese edition)

The following year sensei Kanazawa's second publication also shows his preparation method, consistent with all the previous examples.



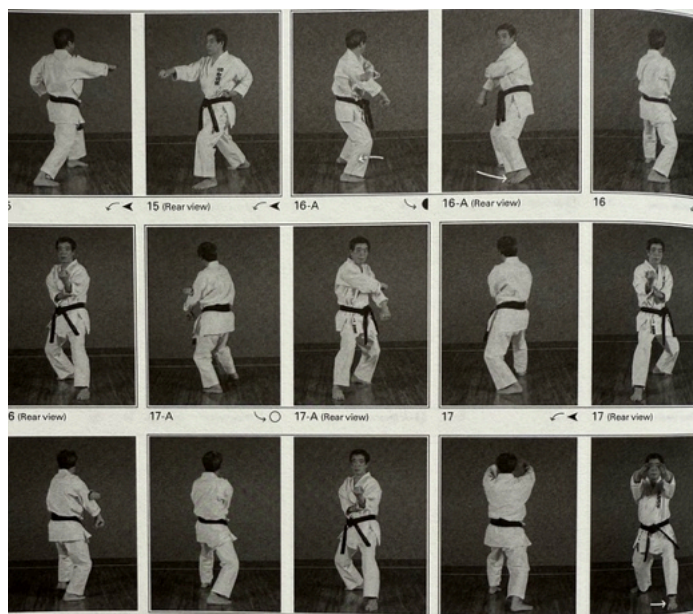
“SKI Kata Vol.1”, Kanazawa H., 1981

In the so called “white books”, the original SKIF publication meant to solidify his methodology and standardize the SKIF technique throughout the federation, sensei Kanazawa display once again his preferred way of executing this technique.



“Karate: The complete Kata”, Kanazawa, H., 2009

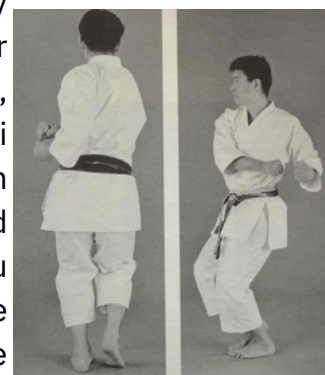
In his last publication, Soke cemented his legacy in this hardcover book, which detailed photos of all the standard kata covered by SKIF, with the additional “Gankaku Sho”. His execution of morote-uke remains unchanged.



Part III - Other Non-SKIF examples

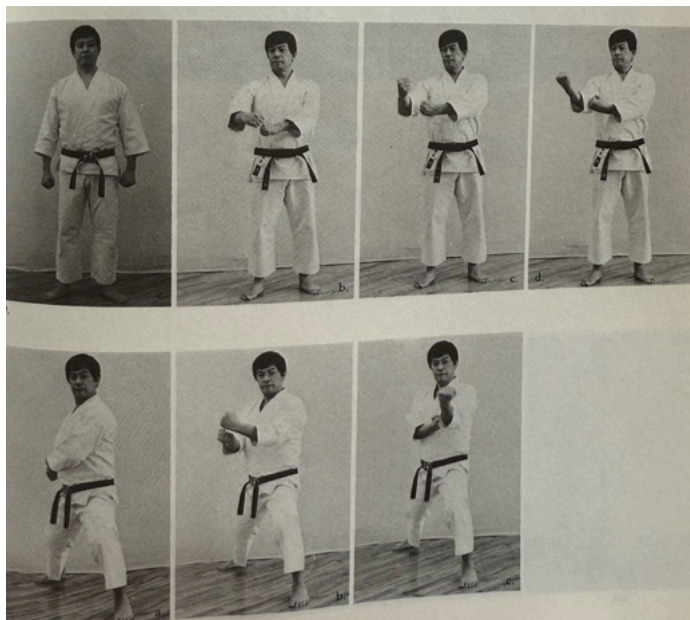
“Shotokan Karate - 10th Kyu to 6th Kyu”, Enoda K., 1996

Sensei Enoda probably was the most popular sensei residing in Europe, since he joined sensei Kanazawa in the UK. In this volume dedicated towards the lower kyu ranks, it is shown the preparation of the morote-uke with both fists close to each other, similar to a koshi-gamae.



**"The Textbook of Modern Karate",
Okazaki T., 1984**

Sensei Okazaki (ISKF) Shows yet another variation where the preparation starts from koshi-gamae. This is similar to example from sensei Enoeda's book.



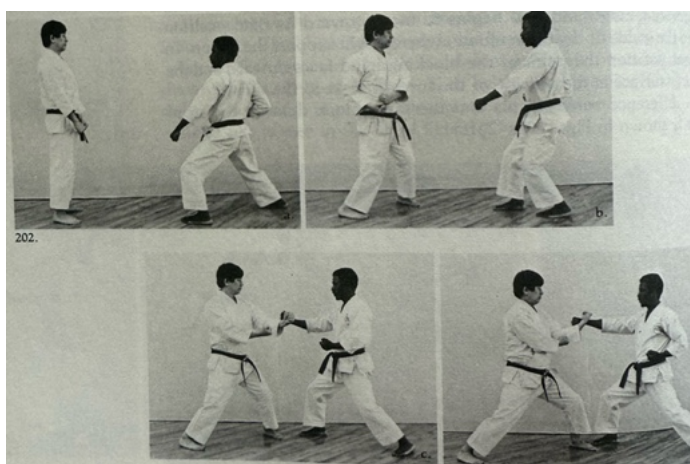
**"The essence of Okinawan Karate-Do"
Nagamine, 1976**

As an example outside of Shotokan, in Sensei Nagamine's Shorin-ryu style, the block is also prepared from a koshi-gamae position.



Note

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Traditional Shōtōkan Karate in High School Curriculum (Update)

by **Richard McGibbon**

This is an update regarding the SKIF karate curriculum being taught in our high school. We are finishing up our third year of karate being offered as a full credit course at our high school. A student can obtain a credit for graduation in Physical Education or Fine Arts. What assisted me was the fact that I have a SKIF License from our organization and I am a licensed Teacher in the State of Maine. Then I had to align our karate curriculum to the State of Maine Learning Results. Nothing in our SKIF curriculum changed, one just had to see the generalities contained in our States guidelines and match them up to what we teach.

This year's group contained 18 students, 3 of which had taken this course last year. Some students had behavioral issues and a few have learning disabilities but our school administration is fully supportive of this program. When I start a new class the students think it is just a gym class, you have to end that attitude quickly. First off you have to simply tell them that this will be different from any other gym class that they have taken during their school career. Explain what the rules are and stick to what you told them. Lead the class by example, show them the technique and then do it with them. I found that having a senpai or helper in this type of class is necessary to the success of the class. Lucky for me our Biology Teacher, Kristi Hayes, is also one of my Brown Belts in our Millinocket Dojo and my Senpai at Stearns High School.

I had to also create a curriculum profile of what I would teach and how I would teach it. One must use "layman's" terminology and not karate terminology so as to be

understandable to the general public, administrators, parents and anyone else who might want to see what we are teaching.

Our karate program has caught the interest of other nearby high schools as a valuable addition to a students education and maybe even as a lifelong pursuit after their school days have ended.

Finally, our special needs students felt fully a part of this class and enjoyed the progress they made during this year. The behaviorally challenged students liked the discipline of the class, which did challenge them at first, but also had a calming effect on them that other teachers noticed.

After my first article published I had inquiries about after school programs, I told them that what we were doing was regarding a course within the schools curriculum offerings. If anyone is thinking about instituting a course at their local high school, one make sure you hold a valid teaching license from your State and a license from your martial arts organization. These two things are going to be a requirement just to get you in the door followed by more work to create and show what you intend to teach. And don't expect a pay increase for this course, it was part of my contract to teach a certain number of courses, but it is very worthwhile. To know that this next generation of my karate student's will have this experience to meet any challenge in life with how they met the challenges they received in their karate course, truly payment enough.

Remember a Black Belt is simply a White Belt who never gave up or walked away from a challenge.

Punching Through the Target

by Ed Marotta

This is the first in a series of articles that explains the physics behind the karate techniques we perform, and how to increase the power in basic karate techniques.

We have heard the following training instructions from Karate instructors during class and during SKIF events.

“Punch through the target”, “Add snap to your techniques”, “Apply Kime before making contact with the target” (bag or makiwara pad), “Keep your center line when stepping or applying your technique”.

As an engineer, I was always interested in the reason and science behind these instructions. I have since found that these instructions are all based in the science of physics. All are methods for generating the maximum power for a technique, and all apply whether it is a block or a strike.

Punch through the target

The physics behind this instruction is based on Newtonian Physics, 2nd law of motion:

$F=ma$ (Force equals mass times acceleration, Newton’s 2nd Law)

In this case for a Karateka, the mass ‘m’ (in the above equation) is their body mass (or weight), and the acceleration ‘a’ (in the above equation) is how quickly (or the change in velocity) they can strike, will determine the Force of a strike. The mass of the Karateka cannot be changed; however, we have control of the acceleration of the punch. The research shows that a karate reverse punch (gyaku-zuki), starting with the fist on the hip (hikite position) and then going out from the

hip to the target has a certain acceleration or velocity pattern. The velocity from start to finish shows that the punching fist starts off at 0 m/s (zero meters per second), then the fist increases in speed, then finally goes back to 0 m/s at the end of the punch. Figure 1 shows the velocity pattern of the reverse punch fist from start to finish. At the 92% - 96% fist positions, the acceleration is at the maximum (represented as the maximum ‘slope’ of the velocity). Based on the force equation, $F=ma$, the punch has the maximum force at these fist positions. For the rest of the fist’s journey, it is slowing down (de-accelerating) and coming to a stop.

The statement “Punch through the target” is a way to have the Karateka hit the target near the 92%-96% positions to generate the maximum amount of force at the target. If the punch hits the target near the end of it journey (100% point) the force would be much less. For example, for an average human arm length of 28 inches (2.33 feet), the maximum force of the punch is at the following fist positions:

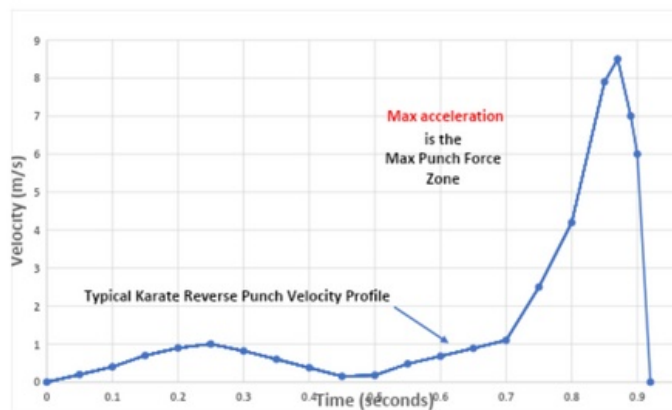
Fist Position (%)	Fist Position (feet)	Max Force before Target (inches)
92	2.1	2.2
96	2.2	1.1

Average Human Arm Length

2.33 feet

The maximum force will then be at the 2.1 to 2.2 feet positions. Therefore, the target should be hit 1.1 – 2.2 inches (2.8 – 5.7 cm) before the fist comes to rest. Or put it another way, the punch should go beyond (“punch through”) the target for 1.1 – 2.2 inches (2.8 – 5.7 cm) to apply the maximum force on the target.

5. Based on physics, fear the opponent who has a small mass but is very fast ($F=ma$, large acceleration, equals large Force).
6. Blocks should be treated as a strike, and the same physics apply to these techniques.



Conclusions

1. Punching Through the Target will generate the maximum amount of force on the target.
2. At the 92% to 96% of the arms length, a punch will generate the maximum amount of force. For a 28-inch arm length (average adult arm length) it means that a karateka should hit the target between 1.1 to 2.2 inches (2.8 to 5.7 cm) before the arm is fully extended.
3. Based on the Force equation, a karateka when faced with being hit, should move back (or away) and ‘ride out’ the punch to get out of the ‘maximum punch force zone’ to lessen the force of an opponent’s punch.
4. Based on physics, fear the opponent who has a large mass and has slow punches ($F=ma$, large mass, equals large Force).

Special Announcements

by SKIF-USA Board of Directors

R.I.P. Shihan Robert Nishimura

We are deeply saddened by the passing of Shihan Robert Nishimura from Hawaii.

SKIF USA Board would like to extend its sincere condolences to his family, friends, and all who were touched by his life and contributions to Karate-Dō.

15th SKIF World Championship Team Selection

SKIF USA is pleased to announce the start of the selection process for the SKIF USA Team for the **15th SKIF World Championship**, to be held in **Antalya, Turkey, November 9–15, 2026**.

To address the increased logistical and financial considerations of international competition, the Tournament and Technical Committees will utilize an application-based selection process, consistent with the method used for the 2023 World Championship.

Each member dojo may submit applications with supporting recommendation for athletes they wish to recommend. The committees will review all submissions and assign available team positions accordingly.

Important Dates

	From	Until
Dojo Membership	January 1	February 28
Individual & Independent Student Membership	January 1	March 30
Licenses (Valid May 2025 – May 2026)	March 1	April 15

New Dan Gradings

Congratulations to all the members who successfully passed their grading tests!

Last Name	First Name	Dojo	Rank	Examiner
Bazantes	Miguel	Shotokan Karate-Do Center	Shodan	M. Murakami
Castillo	Kassandra	Shotokan Karate-Do Florida	Shodan	M. Murakami
Cisnero	Jorge	Texas A & M University Shotokan Karate Club	Shodan	M. Murakami
Correia Da Silva	Sophia	S.K.I.F. Samurai	Shodan	N. Kanazawa
Giang	Steven Hieu	Satsuma Dojo	Shodan	F. Kanazawa
Handman	Jacob	SKIF Waikoloa	Shodan	N. Kanazawa
Hernandez	Emilio	S.K.I.F. Samurai	Shodan	N. Kanazawa
Nagata	Marcus	SKIF Waikoloa	Shodan	N. Kanazawa
Rodriguez	Mathias	Shotokan Karate-Do Florida	Shodan	M. Murakami
Rugama	Zael	S.K.I.F. Samurai	Shodan	M. Murakami
Ventura	Valeria	S.K.I.F. Samurai	Shodan	P. Danos
Ventura	Junior	S.K.I.F. Samurai	Shodan	P. Danos
Frick	Juergen	Satsuma Dojo	Nidan	F. Kanazawa
Lim	Kelli	SKIF Iwilei	Nidan	N. Kanazawa
Mendelsohn	Shalie	Independent	Nidan	M. Murakami
Morita	Mark	Satsuma Dojo	Nidan	F. Kanazawa
Namba	Tetsuya	Satsuma Dojo	Nidan	F. Kanazawa
Suryanarayana	Srinivas	Satsuma Dojo	Nidan	F. Kanazawa
Zhang	Xiwen	Texas A & M University Shotokan Karate Club	Nidan	M. Murakami

Last Name	First Name	Dojo	Update	By
Barnabei	Henry	Shotokan Karate-Do Florida	Sandan	M. Murakami
Lee	William	Satsuma Dojo	Sandan	F. Kanazawa
Lev	Sharon	Satsuma Dojo	Sandan	F. Kanazawa
Tamayose	Kevin	SKIF Iwilei	Yondan	N. Kanazawa
Nouchi	Robert	SKIF Iwilei	Godan	N. Kanazawa
Odani	Norman	SKIF Pearl City Foundation	Godan	N. Kanazawa
Villanueva	Jerry	SKIF Windward	Godan	N. Kanazawa

New Dojos

Welcome to the SKIF-USA!

Dojo	State	Main Instructor
Satsuma Dojo - Alameda Branch	California	Amarjargal Enkhobold / Slauson Kevin
Canal Shotokan Karate	California	Hugo Que Galvez / Ramona Teresa Mendoza

| Upcoming Events

SKIF International & SKIF USA Events

SKIF Japan International Seminar - March 27–29, 2026, Tokyo, Japan

- If you or your students wish to attend, please submit the required information by February 28 so we may complete notification and registration with Japan GHQ.

SKIF Oregon Clinic - February 20-21, 2026, Hillsboro, OR

- Instructor: Rubén Fung
- Host: Hillsboro Shotokan Karate Club
- Contact: secretary@hillsboro-shotokan-karate.com | 971-317-8625

SKIF Houston Gasshuku - March 7–8, 2026, Houston, TX

- Instructor: Manabu Murakami, Shuseki Shihan
- Host: Shotokan Karate-Do Center
- Contact: shotokankaratedocenter@gmail.com | 832-513-0058

SKIF Cincinnati Gasshuku - June 5–7, 2026, Cincinnati, OH

- Instructor: Nobuaki Kanazawa, Kancho
- Hosts: Peak Performance Shotokan Karate-Do, New England Shotokan Karate-Do, and Doshinkai Dojo
- Contact: Rubén Fung – dskdojo1@gmail.com | 832-513-0058

SKIF California Seminar - June 9–10, 2026, San Jose, CA

- Instructor: Nobuaki Kanazawa, Kancho
- Host: Satsuma Dojo
- Contact: Jay Castellano – satsumadojo@outlook.com

SKIF Hawaii Seminar - June 15–22, 2026, Hawaii

- Instructor: Nobuaki Kanazawa, Kancho
- Host: SKIF Hawaii
- Contact: Jerry Villanueva – jerry.villanueva@gmail.com

15th SKIF World Championship - November 9–15, 2025

- Location: Antalya, Turkey

Zoom Training with SKIF GHQ Japan

- Additional details will be provided soon.

| Closing Remarks

We hope you enjoyed the 2025 newsletter. We are looking forward to the next issue. Please continue sending articles, photos and seminar/tournament recaps to our email, or reach us on our social media channels.

We would like to thank all of the contributors for their insightful articles and assistance with the creation of this newsletter.

Stay safe.

Oss!

The Editorial Committee:

Ricardo Neves
Ruben Fung
Chris Johnson

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